

TEACH

SUPPORTS TERTIARY WHY

FOR WHAT-HOW · HOW-WHAT

The Pre-Mortem Protocol

A structured session held before launch: it is twelve months from now, and this failed. **Working backward from imagined failure gives systematic thinkers a concrete doorway into strategic thinking.**

THE DRAIN

Asked to "think big picture," WHAT-HOW and HOW-WHAT profiles reach for the register they trust, specifics, and abstract strategic speculation drains them without producing much. The result is that strategic risk conversations happen without the people who best understand how things actually break.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The pre-mortem flips the register. By declaring the failure as fact and asking for its causes, it converts strategy into diagnosis, which is concrete, systematic work these profiles are exceptional at. The protocol produces a ranked map of real risks, generated by the wiring usually left out of the strategy room.

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 Run it after planning, before commitment.** Late enough that there is a real plan to kill; early enough that findings can change it.
- 2 Enforce the silent writing.** Spoken-first sessions converge on the safe answers. The written round is the protocol.
- 3 Let specifics stay specific.** "The integration fails in week three" is a strategic finding. Do not launder it into abstraction.
- 4 Close the loop at the real twelve months.** Compare imagined failure to actual history. The calibration compounds.

The session

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| 1 Declare the failure | "It is twelve months out. This failed completely." Said as fact, not hypothesis. |
| 2 Write in silence | Everyone lists reasons independently, ten minutes. Silence protects the uncomfortable answers. |
| 3 Cluster the causes | Group the reasons; the clusters are the risk map. |
| 4 Rank by likelihood times damage | A simple two-axis pass, exactly the judgment this wiring does well. |
| 5 Counter the top three | One named owner and one concrete counter per top risk, added to the plan. |

WHAT IT WON'T DO

A pre-mortem surfaces failure paths; it does not choose the destination, it stress-tests one already chosen. Vision work still belongs upstream, and to the people energized by it. This is the tool for making sure their vision survives contact with how things actually work.

IN THE KIT

Facilitation script

Silent-round sheets

Risk map + counter template

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 27 Assumption Audit · **Tool 6** Edge-Case Question Bank · **Tool 23** Problem Reframe Deck